

C++26 Needs To Go Back



To the National Bodies of JTC1/SC22:

The C++ Alliance asks you to send C++26 back: vote No on the DIS ballot, with technical comments, as the Directives unconditionally provide. The authority to approve, defer, or return this draft is yours alone. Contracts reached the draft without the rigorous technical evaluation a permanent language addition demands. A No vote returns that feature for the evaluation it skipped. It leaves reflection, execution, and the rest of the draft intact, and makes no claim about how the feature advanced - only that, on the record, it is not yet ready.

Consensus is a judgment the chair must justify. The chair may, with reasoned determination, rule against the numerical majority. That authority is broad by design, and its counterpart is a recorded reason: why sustained objections were set aside, for a reviewer outside the working group to weigh. That reason was never recorded. Review was compressed, the field-experience step required of comparable safety features was skipped, and design questions reversed repeatedly, yet each turn was entered as consensus with no finding that the opposition had been answered. None of it broke a rule, which is why it cannot be caught from inside: a process built to produce consensus on time will produce it, audited or not. The ballot is where that determination finally faces a reviewer, and only you can be that reviewer.

You are the last line of defense. The ISO system placed the final review outside the working group for a reason. The participants closest to a proposal are the least able to check it. At the ballot, one country holds one vote, the one stage where the size of a delegation counts for nothing. After your vote, no other reviewer stands between the draft and publication. You have seldom needed that defense, and your restraint was appropriate. For three decades the committee was small enough that papers arrived with time to read them. Outcomes stayed provisional until the ballot. Those conditions no longer hold. More than one National Body filed formal opposition to this feature at the Committee Draft - a first in over a decade. National Bodies have returned working group output before, in other ISO committees, and it was never treated as extraordinary. You would be joining them.

Deferral is the conservative act. Approve, and you lock the feature's defects permanently into an international standard, and into the ABI every implementation in your country depends on. Defer, and you give it the evaluation it skipped, at the cost of one cycle. The work does not stop: published papers (P4317, P4324) already show how the feature can return and mature. A ballot exercised once, on the merits, does more than correct this draft: it tells every working group that your mirror committee reads what it produces before publication. To ratify a process you could not review risks your standing. To exercise your oversight is how you build it.

Respectfully,

Vinnie Falco, C++ Alliance

John Spicer, Former INCITS C++ Chair, Former SG21 Chair

J. Daniel Garcia, Head of Delegation for Spain, WG21 and SC22

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